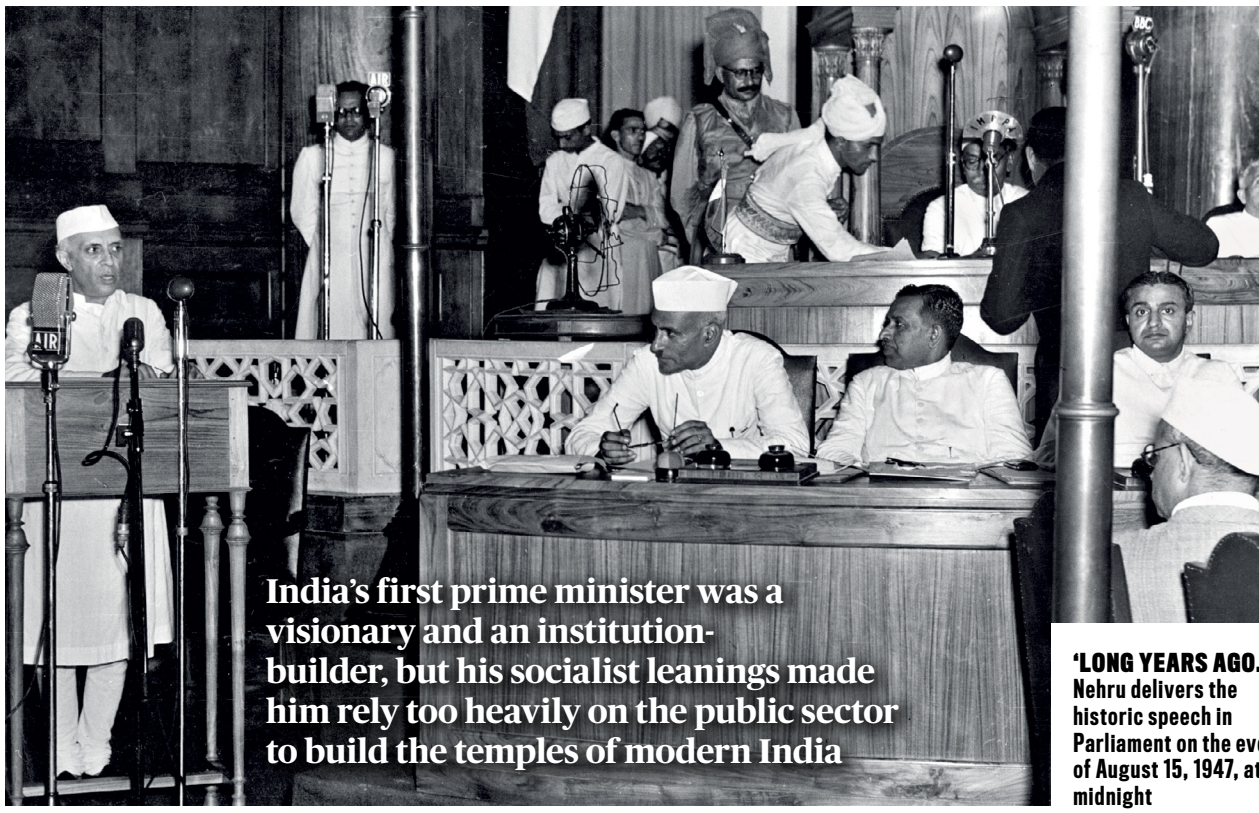
GETTY IMAGES



India's first prime minister was a visionary and an institution-builder, but his socialist leanings made him rely too heavily on the public sector to build the temples of modern India

'LONG YEARS AGO...' Nehru delivers the historic speech in Parliament on the eve of August 15, 1947, at midnight

fare measures, including launching the massive Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee scheme. The result was the largest decline in poverty in decades, with over 250 million Indians being lifted out of the condition during his 10-year reign. When Narendra Modi took over as the prime minister in 2014, he continued this welfarism with a renewed zeal, and at a scorching pace, launching new schemes for the poor, to build toilets, provide tap water to every household, build housing for the needy and subsidise LPG cylinders for cooking. Simultaneously, the prime minister has taken steps to reform the financial sector, with measures such as the Goods and Services Tax and the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code to address the twin balance-sheet crisis. His tenure has also seen a major push towards privatisation, with Air India's sale to Tatas becoming a symbol of that endeavour.

Indeed, India has come far in its development ambitions in these 75 years. For one, we are totally self-sufficient in foodgrains, though lagging in pulses and edible oil production, necessitating import. Most Indians finally have bare necessities such as water, toilets, electricity and road connectivity. Poverty has reduced substantially and life expectancy has gone up to 72 years. Yet there is a long way to go too. Especially with regard to freedom of expression. If a mere tweet can land you in jail, it speaks volumes about just how insecure and intolerant ruling dispensations have become. The state has over the years, under the excuse of protecting national security interests, strengthened its repressive powers and unabashedly abused them. This, when it is incumbent on the Centre and states not to trample upon freedoms enshrined in the Constitution.

In his Independence Day address this year, PM Modi spelled out the 'Paanch Prans' or five goals to achieve in the next 25 years. Foremost among them was to be a 'Vikasit Bharat' or developed country by the time India turns 100 in 2047. To attain that goal faster, governments must learn from the mistakes of the past, especially of not harnessing fully the potential and genius of Indian entrepreneurship. Policymakers must take every step to ensure that the private sector has a level playing field and is spared unnecessary regulations and arbitrary taxation. We must not fall back into the trap of protecting domestic industry in the name of Swadeshi. That will breed inefficiency and render it uncompetitive. Public sector enterprises should be encouraged only in areas where they provide the optimum use of resources: that should be their litmus test. India must make every effort to become globally competitive and to tap into the value chains to boost exports. To become a Vikasit Bharat, experts estimate that the per capita income needs to grow at an average of 12 per cent for the next 25 years. That will enable India to catch up with advanced countries. It's a tall task, but not impossible. We must renew our tryst with destiny without further delay. ■